

A cultural evolution

If there's one thing I have to put down as the most interesting part of my job, it has to be people. Yes, people over the latest and greatest products that flow into our test centre. It's the people you meet, their myriad different tastes in humour, music, movies, favourite web sites that you're exposed to, and the wacky ideas that fly about in our office that really make this job fun.

Recently, we got to talking about the "culture" of technology. We decided to look at this inexplicable deviance in how individuals like to use their technology. What is geek culture really? Can we even attempt to define it? How does said culture really change us, and is it even good to be cultured?

Many believe that technology is what shaped the geek cultures of today, but I think it's always been the other way around.

Looking at the state of the world, it would be easy to segregate it into the haves and have-nots of technology. It's also easy to extrapolate that into the idea that it's usually the first world countries that make up the haves, and the third world countries that make up the have-nots. Simple, right?

Wrong. Every country has within it the same segregation of haves and have-nots. While millions in India don't even have a toilet to use, there are still hundreds of thousands with enough money to buy the latest in technology – often spending much more than people in the US do! Similarly, in the US you will find people who can't write and have never used the Internet in their lives, and yes, some of them have no toilet to call their own.

It's not geographic. Each one of us is a part of a different set of cultures, based on our interests, passions and exposure. It's the friends we keep, the sites we surf, the jokes we share, the products we like, the books and magazines we read, etc., that define us.

So what drove us to geekdom? Some think it was the opening up of our economic border to allow western companies and technology into India. People cite the Internet as the game changer – exposing us to different cultures, increasing the penetration of PCs and mobiles. However, wasn't it the basic need for humans to connect and communicate with one another across distances that brought about post (snail mail), the telephone, and yes, the Internet as well?

Is it mental boredom of the haves that brings about some of the new cultures?

Why did *Kolavari Di* become so popular, or Facebook and Twitter for that matter? With all the useless tweets, pointless Facebook updates and mindless YouTube sensations, one could be tempted to accept the idea that boredom causes us to do stupid stuff, or just watch other people do stupid stuff.

In the end, I think it's more to do with the living conditions and the norms of society we live in. You are what you eat, drink, think and talk about. For example, everyone in the UK seems obsessed with the weather, because it's so unpredictable. Here in India, talking non-stop about careers and salaries, Sachin Tendulkar's hundredth 100, or singing *Kolavari Di* in a cracked voice is popular. It's more localised, more relevant to you.

You are ambushed by ads on all of the popular sites you visit, or get friends spamming you with Dhanush-me-toos singing their own versions. This is because when a culture becomes big enough to be noticed, everyone wants to be a part of it. Many cell phones have Facebook connectivity as the major selling point, or use the word "Android" prominently. It's because we've decided what's cool, and companies do their level best to try and take advantage of it.

What's most beneficial, however, is understanding what new cultures will be big, before they're big. How beneficial? Apple just reported over 13 billion dollars in profit, by doing exactly this. Of course they didn't invent touch interfaces, as many people might believe, but Apple did time the iPhone release to perfection. They also did away with keypads, and brought multi-touch to the masses – of course they weren't the first to showcase multi-touch either, but predictions of cultures is what it's all about.

It's not just about business though – we can also benefit personally from opening up to new cultures. Our cover story attempts to show how this can be achieved, just by broadening what you're exposed to. Think of technology as the evolution of the species, and the various cultures just the genetic mutations that usually form when evolving. What I'm hoping for is the survival of the fittest cultures, which may not necessarily be the most popular today. ■



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"While millions in India don't even have a toilet to use, there are still hundreds of thousands with enough money to buy the latest in technology – often spending much more than people in the US do"

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

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